



Your Expedition Journal

Quest for the Antarctic Circle
Feb 9th - Mar 5th, 2026

Ushuaia & Beagle Channel

Saturday, 21st February 2026

Welcome aboard the *MS Expedition*, or as we affectionately call her, our “little red ship.” A glance around the pier makes it clear that she truly is a small ship. Docked beside a massive cruise liner and even other larger expedition vessels, she may be small, but she is fierce, sitting proudly at the pier.

The energy on board was high, a blend of excitement for the journey ahead and relief that nearly everyone made it in time to sail despite the airport strikes. For many, this is the trip of a lifetime, and there was a palpable sense of gratitude to finally be settled onboard.



The afternoon was filled with welcome briefings, covering everything from ship familiarization to our tentative plans for the coming days. We met our expedition leader, Jenny, who delivered the much-anticipated news about the Drake Passage. It sounds like we may experience a bit of a “Drake Shake,” though hopefully with a favorable wave angle to ease our crossing.

After our first dinner together, we gathered in the lounge for a fun, if slightly chaotic, parka and boot party. Sock preferences, boot fit, and layering strategies quickly became the hottest topics of conversation. “How cold is it really going to be?” many asked. The recurring answer from the expedition team: it depends.

We are already learning that nearly everything on this voyage will depend on the ever-changing weather, and flexibility will be essential in the days ahead. There is something humbling about embarking on a journey so completely at the mercy of nature. In a world where we control so much of our daily lives, this feels like an important and welcome reconnection to the wild.

The evening concluded with the announcement of our 21:00 departure. We headed out on deck to wave goodbye to Ushuaia, spirits high and hearts full of anticipation for the adventure that awaits.



Submitted by: Sarah Keenan, Kayak Assistant.

Photos by: Mark Dunsmuir, Photographer, a) Welcome onboard, b) Goodbye Ushuaia.

At Sea (Bound for Antarctica)

Sunday, 22nd February 2026

After our first night on board the ship we were rocked awake by the sea as we made our way out of the Beagle channel and South of Cape Horn into the Drake Passage. The Drake passage is a notorious body of water; some describe it as the world's most dangerous passage. Today, however, it did not live up to that moniker. Although we did have some swell it certainly was not a full "Drake Shake" with swells only between 3 - 4 metres. Some of our passengers may disagree, but it was a relatively calm day on the Drake today.

After a hearty breakfast, we started our educational lectures. First up was the birdman John, our resident ornithologist. He did a very interesting talk about seabirds of the Southern Ocean. This was followed by Pepper doing a talk about "Why is ice blue?" She also provided valuable information in her lecture about how to not fall in a crevasse. In amongst all of our lecture were various mandatory meetings for all the campers and kayakers and we even managed to fit in a few activities

Pepper, who is also our citizen science coordinator, along with John conducted one of our many citizen science programs on the back deck. First John did a quick work shop on how to use binoculars and we spent a half hour doing a bird survey for eBird, looking for the many species of seabirds he had talked about earlier in his lecture. Even though it was a beautiful day out on the back deck, no birds were spotted during our survey. Not to be disheartened, a survey done with the presence or absence of sightings is still valuable information scientists like to gather.



This was followed by Pepper who explained to us the importance and instructions on how to do a Globe cloud survey by observing and recording cloud cover and type, timed to a NASA satellite fly-over. This helps scientists understand how surface and air temperatures are affected by cloud cover, and how clouds will respond to a changing climate.

We were able to fit in a couple more lectures before dinner. One was by Anastasiia, our historian, who gave a very insightful talk on the "Heroic Age of Antarctic Exploration." This was followed by an informative lecture by our photographer in residence Mark, who gave us great tips and advice on how to take the best photographs of our trip.

After our delicious dinner put on by our galley team, we were treated to a movie and popcorn in our expedition lounge. After a full day of learning, with many people still feeling the effects of the Drake Passage, a nice entertaining evening watching "Happy Feet" was a great way to wind down from our first full day at sea.

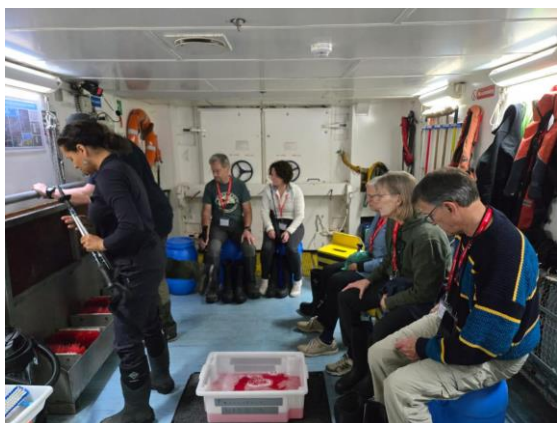
Submitted by: Brad Mason, Naturalist.

Photo: a) Pepper conducting a Globe cloud survey.

Drake Passage (Heading south)

Monday, 23rd February 2026

Well, what a day. We are finally all getting our sea legs and today went much smoother! In the morning we went for breakfast and once more enjoyed fresh fruit, eggs, toast and other goodies before diving right into today's lecture and activity program.



First up we met John, our trusty ornithologist, in the expedition lounge for his highly informative talk about penguins. He told us the main pleasure in watching these animals comes from simply observing their silly behavior and antics, and we cannot wait to get to Antarctica so we can follow his instructions.

Next up after a short break we headed back into the lounge to listen to our marine mammal specialist, Matt Burnaby, tell us all about the cetaceans of the Southern Ocean. He revealed many secrets of these ocean giants, and everyone is very excited to

hopefully catch a few glimpses of these magnificent creatures as they skim the surface of the sea while we observe from our Zodiacs.

After lunch, we headed to the lounge for a biosecurity briefing where we were taught all about how to ensure we don't introduce any non-native species to the pristine coasts of the Antarctic Peninsula.

Following biosecurity there was another change to help assist science groups from around the world as we gathered to meet Pepper on deck 5 Aft for a Globe Cloud Observer survey and weather observation. It was a pretty easy day with distinguishable layers of clouds in the sky, and we all learned a lot about weather observing.

Finally, it was time for the Captain's Cocktail back in the lounge, where we got to lay eyes on our fearless Captain and applaud his team, toasting with a glass of champagne. All in all, it was another wonderful, adventurous day at sea on board the *MS Expedition*. We can't wait to see what awaits us tomorrow!



Submitted by: Pepper Cook, Citizen Science Coordinator.

Photos: a) Biosecurity, b) Globe Cloud Observing.

Half Moon Island & Whalers Bay

Tuesday, 24th February 2026

We awoke to a beautiful morning as our ship approached the South Shetland Islands, having made great time crossing the legendary Drake Passage. Excitement was high, as our first landing in Antarctica was just ahead.

Our destination for the morning was Half Moon Island, a small rocky island that lies next to Livingston Island. It's home to a large Chinstrap penguin colony (with approximately 3,300 breeding pairs), breeding Antarctic terns, Brown Skuas, Kelp Gulls, Wilson's Storm-petrels and Imperial Shags. This was our very first encounter with the brush-tailed penguins - the noisy and charismatic Chinstraps, and also a few Gentoo Penguins. Several Antarctic Fur Seals were also spotted near the shore, resting or playing around. On the island's southwest side, we could also see Argentina's seasonal Cámara Station, which operates during the summer months. Our kayakers set out for their first Antarctic paddle, going along the coastline before venturing around to the far side of the island.



In the afternoon, we reached Whalers Bay on Deception Island, one of the most remarkable places in the South Shetlands. The approach through Neptune's Bellows, a narrow passage that leads directly into the flooded caldera of an active volcano, is always an impressive piece of navigation. Deception Island was named by the American sealer Nathaniel Palmer, because of the deceptive entrance to its inner bay, today known as Port Foster.



Ashore, we explored the haunting remains of the early 20th-century whaling operations run by the Hektor Whaling Company, as well as British Antarctic Base "B," which occupied the site from 1944 until 1969. A volcanic eruption in 1969 caused severe damage and ultimately led to the station's evacuation.



Anastasiia welcomed us near the remains of Bransfield House, sharing stories of early whalers, pioneering flights, and the dramatic history that shaped this remarkable place. Many of us also hiked up Roberts Hill, where sweeping views over the black volcanic beach and the caldera made for a spectacular reward.

We ended this incredible first day in Antarctica in high spirits, gathering together for a live music performance by our onboard musician, Blaise

Submitted by: Anastasiia Ezhova, Historian.

Photos: a) View of Half Moon Island, b) Chinstrap Penguins at Half Moon Island, c & d) Whalers Bay at Deception Island.

Orne Harbor & Cuverville Island

Wednesday, 25th February 2026

In the morning we arrived in our little red ship at Orne Harbour, where once again the weather was calmer than we had expected. Those who managed to reach the summit of Orne were able to admire how intrepid these little Chinstrap Penguins are, breeding at such high altitudes to raise their young. Those of us who finished the hike were rewarded and once again surprised by Humpback Whales swimming around us.



We spotted Chinstraps swimming in the water, and the wind picked up, making our return to the boat a bit more fun and exciting than previous times. Another highlight of Orne Harbor was the vast and booming glacier in the background of our Zodiac cruises. From the water and the top of the hike it was possible to hear very consistent cracking, splashing, and thunderous shifts and the glacier continued its timeless march towards the sea, regularly calving much to our delight.

During lunch we repositioned the ship to the lovely Cuverville Island. This particular island is a special landing, host to one of the largest colonies of Gentoo Penguins in the northern Peninsula. We could certainly detect the colony before we could even spot the individual animals as our sense of smell has already begun to be fine-tuned for the scent of penguin.

We enjoyed hiking along the rocky beach and getting our first encounters with these charismatic birds. Their silly antics never fail to amuse!

In the evening it was time for the moment that half our ship had been equally dreading and also anticipating with glee: camping night! As the campers packed up their belongings, we were treated to an Italian buffet with pizza and pasta as far as the eye could see. The campers headed out to Leith Cove, a tiny island once again surrounded with incredible and very active glaciers calving throughout the night. For those of us who stayed on board, a special treat: a great documentary on penguin behavior, "Spy in the Huddle," was shown on board, giving us an undercover view of the inside of a penguin colony.

Submitted by: Pepper Cook, Citizen Science Coordinator.
Photo: a) Chinstrap Penguins at Orne Harbor.

Neumayer Channel & Port Lockroy

Thursday, 26th February 2026

Campers were coaxed from their uneasy slumbers bright and early in a properly wet and wild Antarctic morning. Those brave souls who spent the night on the ice experienced what it's like to unzip a tent and find yourself in the most remote place on Earth. Wind. Snow. Silence. Not your average backyard campout.

After collecting our frost-kissed adventurers, we transited through the Neumayer Channel under a gray, brooding sky. Icebergs drifted in every direction — quiet, massive reminders of just how small we are out here. Even on a muted day, the scale of Antarctica presses gently on your soul.

By afternoon we reached Port Lockroy on Wiencke Island — the famous Penguin Post Office. Built by the Brits during WWII as part of Operation Tabarin, later used for science, and now run by the UK Antarctic Heritage Trust as a museum and shop. Yes, postcards were mailed. History was admired. Souvenirs were debated. But the real show wasn't inside. Gentoo Penguins bustled around the colony while a Leopard Seal cruised the waters nearby. We watched as it selected a penguin for lunch. Leopard Seals are...thorough. They swing their prey back and forth to extract the meat, leaving behind what can only be described as an empty "penguin jacket." Seabirds cleaned up the rest. Nature is not sentimental — and that's part of its honesty. At Jougla Point, juvenile Imperial Cormorants lined the cliffs, contemplating flight like awkward teenagers on prom night.



This evening we approached the famed Lemaire Channel — towering peaks, drifting ice, and a reminder that nature always gets the final word. The entrance itself was stunning and it was well worth the attempt, but we can't win them all. After dinner, we played a spirited round of *How Big Is It?* — stretching a rope down the hallway and guessing the size of Southern Ocean giants. Some of them are much larger than our imaginations give them credit for. Adult beverages were awarded to the winners, because science thrives on celebration.



Good night, expeditioners. Antarctica never disappoints. Let's see what tomorrow brings.

Submitted by: Blaise Guld, Musician.

Photos by: Mark Dunsmuir, Photographer, a) Wet and wild camping, b) Boat shed at Port Lockroy.

Crossing the Antarctic Circle & The Gullet

Friday, 27th February 2026

We awoke to the gentle motion of the ship as we continued south toward our goal: crossing the Antarctic Circle — a milestone that symbolizes challenge and privilege for any explorer.

At 09:30 we gathered at the stern on Deck 5 to celebrate the moment with a toast and a group photo, officially joining the select few who have ventured beyond 66°33' south. Later, the bravest among us took part in the legendary polar plunge, diving into the icy Antarctic waters amid cheers, adrenaline and, quite possibly - pain and regret.

After lunch, we set course for the narrow Gullet Channel, hoping to avoid circumnavigating Adelaide Island. But Antarctica had other plans. The entrance was completely blocked by dense ice, with towering bergs sealing our path.



Undeterred, Jenny organized a Zodiac scouting operation. With winds blowing at 20–30 knots, we navigated among seals and majestic glaciers while the wind slowly began pushing the ice apart. After two hours, a narrow window opened — enough for the captain to attempt the transit south through the infrequently visited channel.

With patience and precision, we successfully transited the Gullet, weaving between sculpted ice formations in a moment that felt truly alive and unpredictable.

That evening, dinner was filled with stories and celebration. Another successful day aboard the *MS Expedition*, bringing us ever closer to setting foot on the Antarctic continent beneath the legendary Antarctic Circle.

Submitted by: Mauricio Martinez, Kayak Master.

Photos: a) Crabeater Seals and our vessel, b) Gazing at a mighty, reposing Leopard Seal, one of Antarctica's top two predators.

Bongrain & Lainez Pts. & Dog Leg Fjord

Saturday, 28th February 2026

Today was one for the books, folks! We kicked off the morning in Bongrain and Lainez Points. The highlights included walking upon a glacier and viewing late season penguin behavior.



For those brave souls who ventured out on the Zodiacs, you know exactly what I mean when I say it was windier than a squirrel on a caffeine rush and splashier than a toddler in a kiddie pool. By the end, we were all soaked - clothes, hair, and dignity included. But I have to admit, driving those Zodiacs in that chaos was almost like riding a rollercoaster - minus the safety harness and with a lot more water. We were laughing so hard; I think the crew on the other side of the bay heard us!

Now, I think Mother Nature decided we had paid enough karma for the day because suddenly, the weather decided to be nice. The skies cleared up, and we got to explore Dog Leg Fjord. Hands down, one of this author's top favorite spots in Antarctica. The view there is so spectacular, it's like Mother Nature's own masterpiece. You can get surprisingly close to a glacier, safely, I might add, and watch all those glacier outlets pouring out into the fjord like giant icy waterfalls. Plus, the grass, mosses, and lichens? They're basically Antarctica's version of a tiny, resilient jungle.



Honestly, ending the day with a BBQ prepared so kindly by the hotel and kitchen staff was the cherry on top. It was almost surreal - good food, great company, and a view that made you feel like you were on the edge of the world (not literally). All in all, an epic day that proves even in the coldest places, the warmest memories are made. Can't wait to see what tomorrow brings. Maybe a little less splashy, hopefully!

Until then, I'll be dreaming of glaciers, grass, and that crazy Zodiac ride. Cheers!

February 28th, 2026, marks the last day of a common year, as 2026 is not a leap year. That means no extra day in February - just 28 days well spent before March begins!

Submitted by: Devi Rouse, General Naturalist.

Photos by: Devi a.) Lainez Pt. top viewpoint b.) Dog Leg Fjord top Viewpoint.

Red Rock Ridge & Stonington Island

Sunday, 1st March 2026

Waking up along the coast of Neny Fjord just south of 68 degrees is one of the most exciting moments of our adventure so far. Taking a stroll along the outer decks under the imposing shadow of Red Rock Ridge makes the start of the day even more exciting.

After somewhat lengthy Zodiac over open water to a calm cove, we were greeted by a group of Weddell Seals. Only a short walk along the rocky shore brought us to the last Adelie molters clinging to the rocky and snowy cliffs. Just a bit further brought us to skua nesting sites. In a stroke of good luck, we came across several cute and downy Brown Skua chicks. Protected by their watchful parents, the chicks strutted their stuff for the photographers among us.



For those of us with a sense of adventure, which in this case was almost everyone, Fiver (Sarah Keenan) broke new ground, leading us up the ridge to a view point that we've never used before. High above the Adelie colony we were treated to a wonderful view of the ship and surrounding mountains. Using keen eyesight or a pair of binoculars, we could look north towards our afternoon stop at Stonington Island.

Stonington Island, just off the coast of Northeast Glacier, is home to both the oldest U.S. Antarctic station, East Base and UK Base E. Though these bases have been long abandoned, lost to time and the elements, they are well preserved for our eyes only. They are history lessons surrounded by breathtaking panoramas - notably, the site were Jackie Ronne and Jennie Darlington were the first women to over-winter in Antarctica, and spend a full year in Antarctica between 1946 and 1948.

In another stroke of luck, the wind dropped to an almost dead calm and the sea swell flattened, allowing the kayakers to get out onto the water one last time.

As the sun pushed its way from behind the clouds, the popping and cracking of the glacier could be heard by everyone. It wasn't long until the zodiac cruisers and those of us on shore watched as we were dazzled by one massive glacier calving after another.



Submitted by: Mark Dunsmuir.

Photos by: a) Excited Adelie looking to get back to sea, b) Red door at Base E, Stonington Island.

Detaille Island & At Sea (Northbound)

Monday, 2nd March 2026



Wow, what another incredible day on the *MS Expedition*...but sadly our last day of operations. But, we saved one of the best for last, as we were treated in the morning to incredible sights on the wild and wonderful Detaille Island! After another delicious hot breakfast, we retreated to our cabins to get dressed and wait to be called to the gangway one last time.

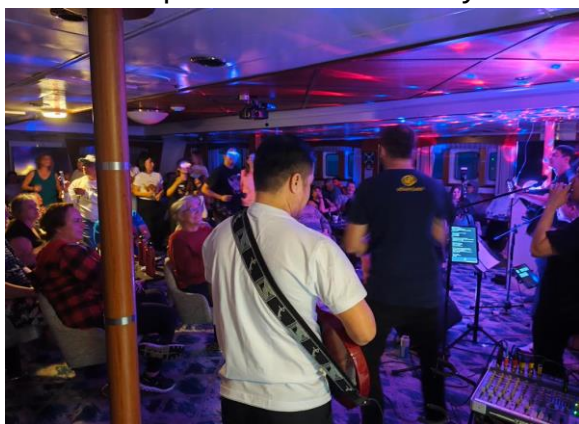
On Detaille Island we witnessed some incredible sights! The sun came out and lit up the icebergs surrounding us as we gazed upon the Adelie Penguins tobogganing down the snow slope. We also had a lot of Weddell and Antarctic Fur Seals, and even a few Humpback Whales around the ship.

But the greatest treat of all was getting to visit inside the old abandoned station, where life was left just as it was at the time of operations. We saw a plethora of museum-quality items left behind including food, books, and even a Scrabble board. We did not get to meet the ghost of the research station referenced by said Scrabble board, but one step inside and you could almost feel its presence.



Then it was time to get back on board the ship for a well-deserved warm lunch and a quick rest before the afternoon's activities. We joined our mammal man Matt in the lounge for his talk, 'Introduction to Pinnipeds of the Antarctic Peninsula' where we learned more about our lovely Weddell, Fur, Leopard and Crabeater Seals.

This was followed by an amazing film screening and question and answer session with our fearless Expedition Leader Jenny. She does some incredible work researching and protecting Whale Sharks in the Galapagos, and inspired us to take action.



After recap and briefing it was time for another incredible dinner before another treat: Blaise and special guests, the Monkey Eating Eagles, played music for us in the lounge to celebrate our amazing voyage together. But the fun was not over yet; we continued on with karaoke! And that wrapped up another wild and spectacular day on board the little red ship we have come to know and love.

Submitted by: Joy Le Pesquer, Naturalist.

Photos: a) Detaille Island, b) Detaille Overview, c) Monkey Eating Eagles Band.

At Sea (Drake Passage)

Tuesday, 3rd March 2026

The Drake Passage greeted us with rare kindness today. Our morning began with a fascinating lecture by John Kernan, our onboard biologist, titled “Life Underfoot.” He opened our eyes to the astonishing complexity of the smallest Antarctic residents — lichens clinging to rock, hardy mites crawling through microscopic ecosystems, and the nearly indestructible water bears (tardigrades) surviving extremes we can barely imagine. John emphasized how life here doesn’t just survive — it adapts with quiet brilliance. He then expanded the lens to the ocean itself. Sea ice, he explained, is not just frozen water; it is the foundation of the Antarctic food web. Within and beneath it blooms diatoms, tiny photosynthetic powerhouses that fuel everything above them. Krill feed on these diatoms, and in turn krill sustain whales, seals, penguins, and seabirds. Without sea ice, the entire system trembles. It was humbling to realize that something so seemingly simple — frozen seawater — underpins one of the most extraordinary ecosystems on Earth.

Later in the morning, Pepper took the stage and immediately filled the room with laughter. She shared stories from her time working in Science Support at Scott Base, New Zealand’s Antarctic research station on Antarctica. Her tales of guiding science teams across the ice were equal parts impressive and hilarious. One story in particular had us in stitches: a helicopter pilot, perhaps feeling a bit too confident, attempted to grab an Emperor Penguin — only to discover that the penguin had other ideas. The lesson was swift, feathery, and unforgettable.



After lunch, we shifted from listening to doing some citizen science, John guided us to look for seabirds while Pepper led a cloud observation session. Later, Anastasiia, our historian, delivered a powerful lecture on the Antarctic Treaty. Signed in 1959, the agreement remains one of the most remarkable examples of international cooperation — a continent set aside for peace and science. The message was clear: Antarctica belongs to no one, and therefore to all of us — and protecting it is both a privilege and a responsibility.

During our final recap and briefing, Pepper surprised us with a rather entertaining “Safety Talk” — sharing with us about all sorts of maritime superstition, from whistling on deck (apparently an invitation for wind) to the long-held taboos sailors carry across generations, etc.

After dinner, the waves at the Drake built slightly, but that did not stop guests gathering in the lounge, laughter and concentration filled the air as guests tackled John’s final exam. The atmosphere was warm, celebratory.

Submitted by: Vanessa Tse, Assistant Camping Leader.

Photos: a) Lounge presentation, b) Pepper and the seabird counting / Cloud observing team.

At Sea (Drake Passage & Beagle Channel)

Wednesday, 4th March 2026

The day began on a much more benevolent note than the previous one had ended, one marked by feeling like beans in a maraca – under partly cloudy skies and over gently rolling seas stroked by brisk winds. It was a not-altogether-unexpected departure from our days and nights in Antarctica. The infamous Drake Passage had lashed us heading south and again steaming north. In between had been days' sublime and calm. In the lee of Cape Horn, off the west, calmer seas were the norm once again as we neared the Beagle Channel.

After breakfast, the day continued with closing presentations. They began with our historian, Anastasiia, wrapping up the voyage's educational component with a presentation of early life in the "Land of Fire." Pepper (with a minor contribution from John and a major one from Devi) followed with a Citizen science wrap-up. After lunch, Storm Simpson's disembarkation briefing aimed at aiding us in transitioning back to "normal" life. Final cloud and wildlife surveys completed voyage contributions to our citizen science programs. And the Ripple Hour hopefully inspired us all when it comes to being responsible stewards of our home: Earth!

Finally, the Captain's Farewell cocktail party, auction, voyage slideshow by our photographer Mark Dunsmuir and unforgettable music night by our musician Blaise Guld brought our incredible journey to a heartfelt close.

The transit north across the Drake Passage from Antarctica to South America is such a striking contrast to the initial sail south, which is marked by giddy anticipation of sights yet unseen. Heading to Ushuaia, we are satiated from our 13-day adventure. From the amazing sights of albatrosses on the wing to rafts of Pintado Petrels following our vessel, from reposing Weddell Seals to stately icebergs, from rugged, ice-covered mountains and windless seascapes coifed in rinsed blue to encounters with Humpback Whales and Leopard Seals, to walking through the time capsules of historic huts and wreckage, and from the crisp scent of cool Antarctic air to the pungent smell of penguins, our senses have been filled to their limits. Today, the ship's manifest contains the same list of names as when she set forth from Ushuaia, yet the ship seems filled with people utterly different from those who departed. This experience has changed us; our past selves are now strangers, and the strangers we met when we first boarded the ship are now our kin. Blown by the winds we met each other by chance and became a random gathering of souls who will likely never meet again. For a short time, we all shared in a single adventure that had a life of its own. Like icebergs, no two adventures are identical. Sadly, also like icebergs, adventures have to come to their end, slowly breaking up into smaller parts and melting away until they are only memories. Too soon now, we will melt back into our former lives, but forever more will the spectacle of Antarctica be a part of us.



Submitted by: John Kernan, Biologist
Photo: Moon and iceberg